

Lesson

9

Concision

*Often I think writing is sheer paring away of oneself leaving
always something thinner, barer, more meager.*

—F. SCOTT FITZGERALD

*The ability to simplify means to eliminate the unnecessary
so that the necessary may speak.*

—HANS HOFMANN

UNDERSTANDING CONCISION

You write more clearly when you match your characters and actions to your subjects and verbs, when you get the right characters into topics and the right words under stress, when you motivate readers with well-crafted introductions, and when you frame your paragraphs, sections, and documents to help readers grasp their global coherence. But readers may still think your prose a long way from graceful if it's anything like this:

In my personal opinion, it is necessary that we should not ignore the opportunity to think over each and every suggestion offered.

That sentence matches characters with subjects and actions with verbs but in too many words: opinion is always personal, so we don't need *personal*, and since this statement is opinion, we don't need *in my opinion*. *Think over* and *not ignore* both mean

consider. *Each and every* is redundant. And suggestion is by definition offered. In fewer words:

✓ We should consider each suggestion.

Though not yet shapely or elegant, that sentence at least has the virtue of compactness or, as we'll call it, concision.

HOW TO REVISE: CONCISION

Readers think you write concisely when you use just enough words to say what you mean. Here are six principles that help you do that:

1. Delete words that mean little or nothing.
2. Delete words that repeat the meaning of other words.
3. Delete words implied by other words.
4. Replace a phrase with a word.
5. Change negatives to affirmatives.
6. Delete useless adjectives and ADVERBS.

Here they are again, in detail:

1. **Delete meaningless words.** Some words are verbal tics that we use as unconsciously as we clear our throats:

kind of actually particular really certain various
virtually individual basically generally given practically

Productivity **actually** depends on **certain** factors that **basically** involve psychology more than **any particular** technology.

- ✓ Productivity depends on psychology more than on technology.

2. **Delete doubled words.** Early in the history of English, writers got into the habit of pairing a French or Latin word with a native English one, because foreign words sounded more learned. Most paired words today are just redundant. Among the common ones:

full and complete	hope and trust	any and all
true and accurate	each and every	basic and fundamental
hope and desire	first and foremost	various and sundry

3. **Delete what readers can infer.** This redundancy is common but hard to identify, because it comes in so many forms.

Redundant Modifiers Often, the meaning of a word implies others, especially its modifier (boldfaced):

Do not try to *predict future* events that **will completely revolutionize** society, because *past history* shows that it is the **final outcome** of minor events that **unexpectedly surprises** us more.

- ✓ Do not try to predict revolutionary events, because history shows that the outcome of minor events surprises us more.

Some common redundancies:

terrible tragedy	various different	free gift
basic fundamentals	future plans	each individual
final outcome	true facts	consensus of opinion

Redundant Categories Every word implies its general category, so you can usually cut a word that names it (boldfaced):

During that *period of time*, the *membrane area* became *pink in color* and *shiny in appearance*.

- ✓ During that *period*, the *membrane* became *pink* and *shiny*.

In doing that, you may have to change an adjective into an adverb:

The holes must be aligned in an *accurate manner*.

- ✓ The holes must be aligned *accurately*.

Sometimes you change an adjective into a noun:

The county manages the *educational system* and *public recreational activities*.

- ✓ The county manages *education* and *public recreation*.

Here are some general nouns (boldfaced) often used redundantly:

large in size	round in shape	honest in character
unusual in nature	of a strange type	area of mathematics
of a bright color	at an early time	in a confused state

General Implications This kind of wordiness is even harder to spot because it can be so diffuse:

Imagine trying to learn the rules for playing the game of chess.

Learn implies *trying*, *rules* implies *playing the game*, *chess* is a *game*. So more concisely,

- ✓ Imagine learning the rules of chess.

4. **Replace a phrase with a word.** This redundancy is especially difficult to fix, because you need a big vocabulary and the wit to use it. For example:

As you carefully go over what you have written to improve wording and catch errors of spelling and punctuation, the thing to do before anything else is to see whether you could use sequences of subjects and verbs instead of the same ideas expressed in nouns.

That is,

- ✓ As you edit, first replace nominalizations with clauses.

I compressed five phrases into five words:

carefully go over what you have written to improve wording and catch errors of spelling and punctuation	→ edit
the thing to do before anything else	→ first
use X instead of Y	→ replace
sequences of subjects and verbs	→ clauses
the same ideas expressed in nouns	→ nominalizations

I can't tell you when to replace a phrase with a word, much less give you the word. I can point out only that you should be alert for opportunities to do so, which is to say, try.

Here are some common phrases (boldfaced) to watch for. Note that some of these let you turn a nominalization into a verb (both italicized):

We must explain **the reason** for the *delay* in the meeting.

- ✓ We must explain **why** the meeting is *delayed*.

Despite the fact that the data were checked, errors occurred.

- ✓ **Even though** the data were checked, errors occurred.

In the event that you finish early, contact this office.

- ✓ **If** you finish early, contact this office.

In a situation where a class closes, you may petition to get in.

- ✓ **When** a class closes, you may petition to get in.

I want to say a few words **concerning the matter of** money.

- ✓ I want to say a few words **about** money.

There is a need for more careful *inspection* of all welds.

- ✓ You **must** *inspect* all welds more carefully.

We **are in a position** to make you an offer.

- ✓ We **can** make you an offer.

It **is possible that** nothing will come of this.

- ✓ Nothing **may** come of this.

Prior to the *end* of the training, apply for your license.

- ✓ **Before** training *ends*, apply for your license.

We have noted a **decrease/increase in the number of** errors.

- ✓ We have noted **fewer/more** errors.

5. **Change negatives to affirmatives.** When you express an idea in a negative form, not only must you use an extra word—*same* → *not different*—but you also force readers to do a kind of algebraic calculation. These two sentences mean much the same thing, but the affirmative is more direct:

Do not write in the negative. → Write in the affirmative.

You can rewrite most negatives:

not careful	→	careless	not many	→	few
not the same	→	different	not often	→	rarely
not allow	→	prevent	not stop	→	continue
not notice	→	overlook	not include	→	omit

Do not translate a negative into an affirmative if you want to emphasize the negative. (Is that such a sentence? I could have written, *Keep a negative sentence when...*)

Some verbs, prepositions, and conjunctions are implicitly negative:

Verbs	<i>preclude, prevent, lack, fail, doubt, reject, avoid, deny, refuse, exclude, contradict, prohibit, bar</i>
Prepositions	<i>without, against, lacking, but for, except</i>
Conjunctions	<i>unless, except when</i>

You can baffle readers if you combine *not* with these negative words. Compare these:

Except when you have **failed** to submit applications **without** documentation, benefits will **not** be **denied**.

- ✓ You will receive benefits only if you submit your documents.
 ✓ To receive benefits, submit your documents.

And you baffle readers completely when you combine negative words with passive verbs and nominalizations:

There should be **no** submission of payments **without** notification of this office, **unless** the payment does **not** exceed \$100.

To revise, first replace the nominalizations with verbs:

Do not **submit** payments if you have not **notified** this office, unless you are **paying** less than \$100.

Then change the negatives into affirmatives:

- ✓ If you pay more than \$100, notify this office first.

6. **Delete adjectives and adverbs.** Many writers can't resist adding useless adjectives and adverbs. Try deleting every adverb and every adjective before a noun, and then restore *only* those that readers need to understand the passage. In this passage, which ones should be restored?

At the heart of the argument culture is our habit of seeing issues and ideas as ~~absolute and irreconcilable~~ principles ~~continually~~ at war. To move beyond this ~~static and limiting~~ view, we can remember the ~~Chinese~~ approach to yin and yang. They are two principles, yes, but they are conceived not as ~~irreconcilable polar~~ opposites but as elements that coexist and should be brought into balance ~~as much as possible~~. As sociolinguist Suzanne Wong Scollon notes, "Yin is always present in and changing into yang and vice versa." How can we translate this ~~abstract~~ idea into ~~daily~~ practice?

—Deborah Tannen, *The Argument Culture: Stopping America's War of Words*

Exercise 9.1

Prune the redundancy from these sentences.

1. Critics cannot avoid employing complex and abstract technical terms if they are to successfully analyze literary texts and discuss them in a meaningful way.
2. Scientific research generally depends on fully accurate data if it is to offer theories that will allow us to predict the future in a plausible way.
3. Most likely, a majority of all patients who appear at a public medical clinical facility do not expect special medical attention or treatment, because their particular health problems and concerns are often not major and for the most part can usually be adequately treated without much time, effort, and attention.

4. Notwithstanding the fact that all legal restrictions on the use of firearms are the subject of heated debate and argument, it is necessary that the general public not stop carrying on discussions pro and con in regard to them.

Where appropriate, change the following negatives to affirmatives, and do any more editing you think useful.

5. There is no possibility in regard to a reduction in the size of the federal deficit if reductions in federal spending are not introduced.
6. Do not discontinue medication unless symptoms of dizziness and nausea are not present for six hours.

Exercise 9.2

Here are sentences from two "free" offers.

You will not be charged your first monthly fee unless you don't cancel within the first thirty days.

To avoid being charged your first monthly fee, cancel your membership within the first thirty days.

Which is less clear? Why might it have been written like that? Revise it.

REDUNDANT METADISCOURSE

Lesson 4 described metadiscourse as language that refers to the following:

- the writer's intentions: *to sum up, candidly, I believe*
- directions to the reader: *note that, consider now, as you see*
- the structure of the text: *first, finally, in this section*

Almost everything you write needs some metadiscourse, but too much buries your ideas:

The last point I would like to make is that in regard to men-women relationships, it is important to keep in mind that the greatest changes have occurred in how they work together.

Only nine of those thirty-four words address men-women relationships:

men-women relationships...greatest changes...how they work together.

The rest is metadiscourse. When we prune it, we tighten the sentence:

The greatest changes in men-women relationships have occurred in how they work together.

Now that we see what the sentence says, we can make it still more direct:

- ✓ Men and women have changed their relationships most in how they work together.

How writers use metadiscourse varies by field, but you can usually cut these two types:

1. **Metadiscourse That Attributes Your Ideas to a Source** Don't announce that something has been *observed, noticed, noted*, and so on; just state the fact:

High divorce rates **have been observed** to occur in areas that **have been determined to have** low population density.

- ✓ High divorce rates occur in areas with low population density.

2. **Metadiscourse That Announces Your Topic** The boldfaced phrases tell your reader that you are about to state what your sentence is "about":

This section introduces another problem, that of noise pollution. **The first thing to say about it is** that noise pollution exists not only...

Readers catch the topic more easily if you reduce the metadiscourse:

- ✓ **Another** problem is noise pollution. **First**, it exists not only...

HEDGES AND INTENSIFIERS

Another kind of metadiscourse reflects the writer's certainty about what she is claiming. *Hedges* qualify your certainty; *intensifiers* increase it. Both can be redundant when used excessively. But they can also be useful, because they signal how well you balance caution and confidence and therefore influence how readers judge your character.

Hedges

These are common hedges:

- Adverbs** *usually, often, sometimes, almost, virtually, possibly, allegedly, arguably, perhaps, apparently,*

*in some ways, to a certain extent, somewhat,
in some/certain respects*

Adjectives	<i>most, many, some, a certain number of</i>
Verbs	<i>may, might, can, could, seem, tend, appear, suggest, indicate</i>

Too much hedging sounds mealy-mouthed, like this:

There **seems to be some** evidence to **suggest** that **certain** differences between Japanese and Western rhetoric **could** derive from historical influences **possibly** traceable to Japan's cultural isolation and Europe's history of cross-cultural contacts.

On the other hand, only a fool or someone with massive historical evidence would make an assertion as flatly certain as this:

This evidence **proves** that Japanese and Western rhetorics differ because of Japan's cultural isolation and Europe's history of cross-cultural contacts.

In most academic writing, we more often state claims closer to this (note my own hedging):

- ✓ This evidence **suggests** that **aspects** of Japanese and Western rhetoric differ because of Japan's cultural isolation and Europe's history of cross-cultural contacts.

The verbs *suggest* and *indicate* let you state a claim about which you are less than 100-percent certain, but confident enough to propose:

- ✓ The evidence **indicates** that some of these questions remain unresolved.
- ✓ These data **suggest** that further studies are necessary.

Even confident scientists hedge. This next paragraph introduced the most significant breakthrough in the history of genetics, the discovery of the double helix of DNA. If anyone was entitled to be assertive, it was Crick and Watson. But they chose to be diffident (note, too, the first person *we*; hedges are boldfaced):

We **wish to suggest a** [not *the*] structure for the salt of deoxyribose nucleic acid (D.N.A.). . . . A structure for nucleic acid has already been proposed by Pauling and Corey. . . . **In our opinion**, this structure is unsatisfactory for two reasons: (1) **We believe** that the material which gives the X-ray diagrams is the salt, not the free acid. . . . (2) **Some** of the van der Waals distances **appear** to be too small.

—J. D. Watson and F. H. C. Crick,
"Molecular Structure of Nucleic Acids"

Intensifiers

These are common intensifiers:

Adverbs	<i>very, pretty, quite, rather, clearly, obviously, undoubtedly, certainly, of course, indeed, inevitably, invariably, always, literally</i>
Adjectives	<i>key, central, crucial, basic, fundamental, major, principal, essential</i>
Verbs	<i>show, prove, establish, as you/we/everyone knows/can see, it is clear/obvious that</i>

The most common intensifier, however, is the absence of a hedge. Without the hedges, Crick and Watson's claim would be more concise but more aggressive. Compare this. I boldface the stronger words, but most of the aggressive tone comes from the *absence* of hedges:

We **wish to suggest state here a** the structure for the salt of deoxyribose nucleic acid (D.N.A.). . . . A structure for nucleic acid has already been proposed by Pauling and Corey. . . . **In our opinion**, [T]his structure is unsatisfactory for two reasons: (1) **We believe that** [T]he material which gives the X-ray diagrams is the salt, not the free acid. . . . (2) **Some of** [T]he van der Waals distances **appear to be are** too small.

Confident writers use intensifiers less often than they use hedges because they want to avoid sounding as assertive as this:

For a century now, **all** liberals have argued against **any** censorship of art, and **every** court has found their arguments so **completely** persuasive that **not a person any** longer remembers how they were countered. As a result, today, censorship is **totally** a thing of the past.

Some writers think that kind of aggressive style is persuasive. Quite the opposite. If you state a claim moderately, readers are more likely to consider it thoughtfully:

For **about** a century now, **many** liberals have argued against censorship of art, and **most** courts have found their arguments persuasive **enough** that **few** people remember **exactly** how they were countered. As a result, today, censorship is **virtually** a thing of the past.

QUICK TIP When most readers read a sentence that begins with something like *obviously, undoubtedly, it is clear that, there is no question that*, and so on, they reflexively think the opposite.

Exercise 9.3

Edit these for both unnecessary metadiscourse and redundancy.

1. But, on the other hand, we can perhaps point out that there may always be TV programming to appeal to our most prurient and, therefore, lowest interests.
2. In this particular section, I intend to discuss my position about the possible need to dispense with the standard approach to plea bargaining. I believe this for two reasons. The first reason is that there is the possibility of letting hardened criminals avoid receiving their just punishment. The second reason is the following: plea bargaining seems to encourage a growing lack of respect for the judicial system.
3. Depending on the particular position that one takes on this question, the educational system has taken on a degree of importance that may be equal to or perhaps even exceed the family as a major source of transmission of social values.
4. It is my belief that in regard to terrestrial-type snakes, an assumption can be made that there are probably none in unmapped areas of the world surpassing the size of those we already have knowledge of.

CONCISE, NOT TERSE

Having stressed concision so strongly, I must now step back. Readers don't like flab, but neither do they like a style so terse that it's all gristle and bone. Here is some amiable advice from the most widely read book on style, Strunk and White's *The Elements of Style*:

Revising is part of writing. Few writers are so expert that they can produce what they are after on the first try. Quite often you will discover, on examining the completed work, that there are serious flaws in the arrangement of the material, calling for transpositions. When this is the case, a word processor can save you time and labor as you rearrange the manuscript. You can select material on the screen and move it to a more appropriate spot, or, if you cannot find the right spot, you can move the material to the end of the manuscript until you decide whether to delete it. Some writers find that working with a printed copy of the manuscript helps them to visualize the process of change; others prefer to revise entirely on screen. Above all, do not be afraid to experiment with what you have written. Save both the original and the revised versions; you can always use the computer to restore the

manuscript to its original condition, should that course seem best. Remember, it is no sign of weakness or defeat that your manuscript ends up in need of major surgery. This is a common occurrence in all writing, and among the best writers. (205 words)

We can shorten that paragraph just by erasing its redundancy:

Revising is part of writing. Few writers ~~are so expert that they can produce what they are after on the first try.~~ **Quite** Often you will discover ~~on examining the completed work, that there are serious flaws in the arrangement of the material, calling for transpositions.~~ When this is the case, a word processor can save you time and labor as you rearrange the manuscript. You can ~~select material on the screen and move [material] to a more appropriate spot, or, if you cannot find the right spot, you can move the material to the end of the manuscript until you decide whether to delete it.~~ Some writers find that working with a printed ~~copy of the~~ manuscript helps them to visualize the process of change; others prefer to revise ~~entirely~~ on screen. Above all, ~~do not be afraid to experiment with what you have written.~~ Save both the original and the revised versions; you can always ~~use the computer to restore the manuscript to its original condition, should that course seem best.~~ **Remember,** It is no sign of weakness or defeat that your manuscript ~~ends up in need[s] of major surgery.~~ This is a common occurrence in all writing, and among the best writers. (149 words)

With some rewording, we can cut that version by another third (revisions are italicized):

Revising is part of writing, *because* few writers ~~produce what they are after on the first try write perfect first drafts.~~ *If you use a word processor and find* ~~Often you will discover~~ flaws in your arrangement, of the material. ~~When this is the case, a word processor can save you time and labor as you rearrange the manuscript.~~ you can move material to a more appropriate spot, or, if you cannot find *one, the* right spot, ~~you can move the material to the end of the manuscript until you decide whether to delete it.~~ Some writers find ~~that working with~~ a printed manuscript helps them to visualize ~~the process of~~ change; others ~~prefer to~~ revise on screen. Above all, experiment. Save ~~both~~ the original ~~and the revised~~ version; you can always *go back to it* ~~restore the manuscript to its original condition.~~ It is no sign of weakness or defeat that your manuscript needs surgery. This is common in all writing, and among the best writers. (99 words)

And if we cut to the bone, we can reduce that in half:

Most writers revise because few write a perfect first draft. If you work on a computer, you can rearrange the parts by moving them around. If you save the original, you can always go back to it. Even great writers revise, so if your manuscript needs surgery, it signals no weakness. (51 words)

But in reducing that paragraph to a quarter of its original length, I've also stripped away its garrulous charm, a tradeoff that many readers would reject.

I can't tell you when you've written so concisely that your readers think you are terse, even abrupt. That's why you should listen to what readers say about your writing. They know what you never can: how it feels to be your reader.

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Exercise 9.4

Revise a passage from a reading as I did the passage from Strunk and White's *The Elements of Style* (pp. 132–133). Pick a long paragraph or section (about 200 words). Now, shorten it to about 150 words, 100 words, 50 words. What does that passage gain or lose with each of these revisions?

Now do the same with a passage from your own writing.

Exercise 9.5

Every piece of writing needs some metadiscourse, but too much buries your ideas. Have a reader go through several pages of your writing and highlight all the metadiscourse. With your reader, address the following questions: Which instances of metadiscourse are useful, and which are unnecessary? Are there places without metadiscourse where some would be helpful? Revise as necessary.

SUMMING UP

You need more than concision to guarantee grace, but when you clear away deadwood, you can see the shape of a sentence more clearly.

1. Meaningless words

Some polling sites reported various technical problems, but these did not really affect the election's actual result.

- ✓ Some polling sites reported technical problems, but these did not affect the election's result.

2. Redundant pairs

If and when we can define our final aims and goals, each and every member of our group will be ready and willing to offer aid and assistance.

- ✓ If we define our goals, we will all be ready to help.

3. Redundant modifiers

In the business world of today, official governmental red tape seriously destroys initiative among individual businesses.

- ✓ Government red tape destroys business initiative.

4. Redundant categories

In the area of education, tight financial conditions are forcing school boards to cut nonessential expenses.

- ✓ Tight finances are forcing school boards to cut nonessentials.

5. Obvious implications

Energy used to power industries and homes will in years to come cost more money.

- ✓ Energy will eventually cost more.

6. A phrase for a word

A sail-powered craft that has turned on its side or completely over must remain buoyant enough so that it will bear the weight of those individuals who were aboard.

- ✓ A capsized sailboat must support those on it.

7. Indirect negatives

There is no reason not to believe that engineering malfunctions in nuclear energy systems cannot be anticipated.

- ✓ Malfunctions in nuclear energy systems will surprise us.

8. Excessive metadiscourse

It is almost certainly the case that totalitarian systems cannot allow a society to have what we would define as stable social relationships.

- ✓ Totalitarianism prevents stable social relationships.

9. Hedges and intensifiers

The only principle here is the Goldilocks rule: not too much, not too little, but just right. This is a matter where you have to develop and then trust your ear.

- Too certain:** In my research, **I prove** that people with guns in their homes use them to kill themselves or family members instead of to protect themselves from intruders.
- Too uncertain:** **Some** of my recent research **seems** to imply that there **may** be a **risk** that certain people with guns in their homes **could be more prone** to use them to kill themselves or family members than to protect themselves from **possible** intruders.
- Just right?** My research indicates that people with guns in their homes are more likely to use them to kill themselves or family members than they are to protect themselves from intruders.

Lesson

10

Shape

The structure of every sentence is a lesson in logic.

—JOHN STUART MILL

*A long complicated sentence should force itself upon you,
make you know yourself knowing it.*

—GERTRUDE STEIN

*You never know what is enough until you know what is more
than enough.*

—WILLIAM BLAKE

UNDERSTANDING THE SHAPE OF SENTENCES

If you can write clear and concise sentences, you have achieved much. But a writer who can't write a clear sentence longer than twenty words or so is like a composer who can write only jingles. Some advise against long sentences, but you cannot communicate every complex idea in a short one: you have to know how to write a sentence that is both long and clear.

Consider this sentence:

In addition to the continual disagreements between Democrats and Republicans on the issues of the day, an explanation of why they so deeply distrust one another must include the divergent values and principles that give them their motivation, the support that arises from their distinct constituencies, and an acceleration of the history of conflict between them.

Even if that idea needs all those fifty-six words (it doesn't), they could be arranged into a more shapely sentence.

We can start revising by editing the abstractions into characters/subjects and actions/verbs and then breaking the sentence into shorter ones:

We want to explain why Democrats and Republicans have come to so deeply distrust one another. One reason is their continual disagreements on the issues of the day. We must also consider the divergent values and principles that motivate them, the distinct constituencies that support them, and the accelerating history of conflict between them.

But that passage feels choppy. We prefer something like this:

- ✓ To explain why Democrats and Republicans have come to so deeply distrust one another, we must consider not only their continual disagreements on the issues of the day but also the divergent values and principles that motivate them, the distinct constituencies that support them, and the accelerating history of conflict between them.

That sentence is only four words shorter than the first, but it is not ungainly. So it can't be length alone that makes a long sentence difficult. In this lesson, I focus on how to write longer sentences that are also clear and shapely.

Readers get a sense of shapeless length from four things:

- They don't find a sentence's point near its beginning.
- They have to wait too long to get to the verb in the main clause.
- After the verb, they have to slog through a series of tacked-on phrases and subordinate clauses.
- They are stopped by one interruption after another.

STARTING WITH YOUR POINT

Compare these two sentences:

High-deductible health plans and Health Saving Accounts into which workers and their employers make tax-deductible deposits result in workers taking more responsibility for their health care.

- ✓ Workers take more responsibility for their health care when they adopt high-deductible insurance plans and Health Saving Accounts into which they and their employers deposit tax-deductible contributions.

Unlike that lumbering first sentence, the second begins not with a long, abstract subject but with a short, concrete one familiar to

readers, directly followed by a verb stating a specific action: *Workers take . . .*

But it differs in another way too. That first sentence feels backward. We have to read more than twenty words before we see their relevance to its key claim, to its most important point: that workers take responsibility for their health care.

[High-deductible health plans and Health Saving Accounts into which workers and their employers make tax-deductible deposits]^{explanation/}
support [result in workers taking more responsibility for their health
care.]^{point}

In contrast, the second sentence opens with an eight-word main clause stating its most important point clearly and concisely:

- ✓ [Workers take more responsibility for their health care]^{point} [when they adopt high-deductible insurance plans and Health Saving Accounts into which they and their employers make tax-deductible deposits.]^{explanation/support}

When we read its point first, we can anticipate the relevance of the next nineteen words *even before we read them*.

Here is a very general principle about how we read: we can best manage complexity when we begin with something short and direct that frames the more complex information that follows. We have seen how that principle applies to individual subjects and verbs. But it also applies to the *logical* elements of a long sentence, to its point and to its explanation or supporting information. When a point is dribbled out or delayed, we have to reconstruct it, then mentally reassemble the sentence into its logical parts. A point clearly stated up front gives us a context to understand the complexity that follows.

In fact, this principle of simple-before-complex applies to even larger units:

- Begin a paragraph with a sentence (or two) expressing its point so that readers can understand what follows (see pp. 115–116).
- Begin a section of a document with a paragraph or two stating its point (see pp. 110–113).
- Do the same for a whole document: begin with an introduction that states its point and frames the rest (see pp. 95–103).

Sentence, paragraph, section, or whole—how quickly, concisely, and *helpfully* you begin determines how easily your readers understand what follows.

HOW TO REVISE: LONG OPENINGS

Readers like to find a sentence's point near its beginning, but they won't if a sentence takes forever to get started:

Since most undergraduate students change their fields of study at least once during their college careers, many more than once, first-year students who are not certain about their program of studies should not load up their schedules to meet requirements for a particular program.

That sentence takes thirty-one words to get to its main verb, *should . . . load up*. Here are two rules of thumb about beginning a sentence: (1) Get to the subject of the main clause quickly. (2) Get to the verb and object quickly.

Rule of Thumb 1: Get to the Subject Quickly

We have a problem with sentences that open with long introductory phrases and clauses, because as we read them, we have to keep in mind that the subject and verb of a main clause are still to come, and that load on our memory hinders easy understanding.

Compare these two versions. In (1a) we have to read and understand seventeen words before reading the main subject (underlined) and verb (capitalized). In (1b), we get past the main subject and verb in just six words:

1a. **Since most undergraduate students change their major fields of study at least once during their college careers, first-year students** who are not certain about the program of studies they want to pursue **SHOULD NOT LOAD UP** their schedules to meet requirements for a particular program.

- ✓ 1b. **First-year students** **SHOULD NOT LOAD UP** their schedules with requirements for a particular program if they are not certain about the program of studies they want to pursue, because **most change their major fields of study at least once during their college careers.**

When you find a sentence with a very long introductory clause, try moving that clause to the end. If it doesn't fit there, try turning it into a sentence of its own.

However, clauses beginning with *if*, *since*, *when*, and *although* usually refer to ideas already known and tend therefore to appear early in a sentence. If you choose to begin with such a clause, keep it short.

An exception is the style called "periodic" or "suspended," in which writers deliberately pile up introductory subordinate clauses

(subordinating conjunctions boldfaced) to delay and thereby heighten the impact of a concluding main clause (italicized):

When a society spends more on its pets than it does on its homeless, **when** it rewards those who hit a ball the farthest more highly than those who care most deeply for its neediest, **when** it takes more interest in the juvenile behavior of its richest children than in the deficient education of its poorest, *it has lost its moral center.*

Used sparingly, this kind of sentence can have a dramatic impact, especially when the last few words of the last clause are appropriately stressed. I discuss this matter again in Lesson 11.

Rule of Thumb 2: Get to the Verb and Object Quickly

Readers also want to get past the main subject to its verb and object. Therefore,

- Avoid long, abstract subjects.
- Avoid interrupting the subject-verb connection.
- Avoid interrupting the verb-object connection.

Avoid long, abstract subjects. Revise long subjects into short ones. Start by underlining whole subjects. If you find a subject longer than seven or eight words that includes a nominalization, especially as the simple subject, try turning the nominalization into a verb and using a character as its subject:

The company's understanding of the drivers of its profitability in the Asian market for small electronics helped it pursue opportunities in Africa.

- ✓ **The company** was able to pursue opportunities in Africa because it **UNDERSTOOD** what drove profitability in the Asian market for small electronics.

A subject can also be long if it includes a long relative clause:

A company that focuses on hiring the best personnel and then trains them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees.

Try turning the relative clause into an introductory subordinate clause beginning with *when* or *if*:

- ✓ **When a company focuses on hiring the best personnel and then trains them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs**, it is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees.

But if the introductory clause turns out to be as long as that one, try moving it to the end of its sentence, especially if (1) the main clause is short and expresses the point of the sentence and (2) the moveable clause expresses newer and more complex information that supports or elaborates on the main clause.

- ✓ A company is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees **when it focuses on hiring the best personnel and then trains them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs.**

Or better yet, perhaps, turn it into a sentence of its own:

- ✓ Some companies focus on hiring the best personnel and then train them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs later. **Such companies are likely to earn the loyalty of their employees.**

Avoid interrupting the subject-verb connection. You frustrate readers when you interrupt the connection between a subject and verb, like this:

Some scientists, **because they write in a style that is impersonal and abstract**, do not easily communicate with laypeople.

That *because* clause after the subject forces us to hold our mental breath until we reach the verb, *do . . . communicate*. Move the interruption to the beginning or end of the sentence, depending on whether it connects more closely to what precedes or follows it (note the *since* instead of *because*).

- ✓ Since some scientists write in a style that is impersonal and abstract, they do **not easily communicate with laypeople. This lack of communication damages . . .**
- ✓ Some scientists do not easily communicate with laypeople because they write in **a style that is impersonal and abstract. It is a kind of style filled with passives and . . .**

We mind short interruptions less:

- ✓ Some scientists **deliberately** write in a style that is impersonal and abstract.

Avoid interrupting the verb-object connection. We also like to get quickly past the verb to its object. This sentence doesn't let us do that:

We must develop, **if we are to become competitive with other companies in our region**, a core of knowledge regarding the state of the art in effective industrial organizations.

Move the interrupting element to the beginning or end of the sentence, depending on what comes next:

- ✓ **If we are to compete with other companies in our region**, we must develop a core of knowledge about the state of the art in effective industrial organizations. **Such organizations provide . . .**
- ✓ We must develop a core of knowledge about the state of the art in effective industrial organizations **if we are to compete with other companies in our region. Increasing competition . . .**

When a prepositional phrase you can move is shorter than a long object, you can also try putting the phrase between the verb and object:

In a long sentence, put the newest and most important information that you want your reader to remember **at its end**.

- ✓ In a long sentence, put **at its end** the newest and most important information that you want your reader to remember.

Here's the point: Readers read most easily when you quickly get them to the subject of your main clause and then past that subject to its verb and object. Avoid long introductory phrases and clauses, long subjects, and interruptions between subjects and verbs and between verbs and objects.

Exercise 10.1

These sentences have long subjects. Revise.

1. Explaining why Shakespeare decided to have Lady Macbeth die off stage rather than letting the audience see her die has to do with understanding the audience's reactions to Macbeth's death.
2. An agreement by the film industry and by television producers on limiting characters using cigarettes, even if carried out, would do little to discourage young people from smoking.
3. A student's right to have access to his or her own records, including medical records, academic reports, and confidential comments by advisers, will generally take precedence over an institution's desire to keep records private, except when limitations of those rights under specified circumstances are agreed to by students during registration.

These sentences are ungainly because of interruptions. First, eliminate wordiness. Then correct the interruption.

4. TV "reality" shows, because they have an appeal to our fascination with real-life conflict because of our voyeuristic impulses, are about the most popular shows that are regularly scheduled to appear on TV.
5. Insistence that there is no proof by scientific means of a causal link between tobacco consumption and various disease entities such as cardiac heart diseases and malignant growth, despite the fact that there is a strong statistical correlation between smoking behavior and such diseases, is no longer the officially stated position of cigarette companies.
6. The continued and unabated emission of carbon dioxide gas into the atmosphere, unless there is a marked reduction, will eventually result in serious changes in the climate of the world as we know it today.

These sentences have long introductory phrases and clauses. Revise. Try to open your revised sentence with its point.

7. While grade inflation has been a subject of debate by teachers and administrators and even in newspapers, employers looking for people with high levels of technical and analytical skills have not had difficulty identifying desirable candidates.
8. Although one way to prevent foreign piracy of DVDs is for criminal justice systems of foreign countries to move cases faster through their systems and for stiffer penalties to be imposed, no improvement in the level of expertise of judges who hear these cases is expected any time in the immediate future.
9. Since school officials responsible for setting policy about school security have said that local principals may require students to pass through metal detectors before entering a school building, the need to educate parents and students about the seriousness of bringing onto school property anything that looks like a weapon must be made a part of the total package of school security.

HOW TO REVISE: SPRAWLING ENDINGS

This next sentence starts well but then sprawls through a string of four explanatory subordinate clauses:

No scientific advance is more exciting than genetic engineering,^{point} which is a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, which are the genes and chromosomes that tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts that constitute our bodies.^{explanation}

Graphically, it looks like this:

No scientific advance is more exciting than genetic engineering,
[point and main subject and verb]

which is a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, [tacked-on relative clause]

which are the genes and chromosomes [tacked-on relative clause]

that tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts
[tacked-on relative clause]

that constitute our bodies. [final tacked-on relative clause]

You can identify this problem by having someone read your writing aloud. If that reader hesitates, stumbles over words, or runs out of breath before getting to the end of a sentence, so will someone reading your writing silently. You can revise in four ways: cut, turn subordinate clauses into independent sentences, change clauses to modifying phrases, or coordinate.

1. Cut

Try reducing some of the relative clauses to phrases by deleting *who/that/which* + *is/was*, etc.:

- ✓ Of the many areas of science important to our future, few are more promising than genetic engineering, ~~which is~~ a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, ~~which are~~ the genes and chromosomes that tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts that constitute our bodies.

Occasionally, you have to turn the remaining verb into a PRESENT PARTICIPLE by adding *-ing*:

The day is coming when we will all have numbers **that will identify** our financial transactions so that the IRS can monitor all activities **that involve** economic activity.

- ✓ The day is coming when we will all have numbers ~~that will identify~~ our financial transactions so that the IRS can monitor all activities **that involving** economic activity.

2. Turn Subordinate Clauses into Independent Sentences

- ✓ Many areas of science are important to our future, but few are more promising than genetic engineering. It is a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, the genes and chromosomes that tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts that constitute our bodies.

3. Change Clauses to Modifying Phrases

You can write a long sentence but still avoid sprawl if you change relative clauses to one of three kinds of APPOSITIVE: a *resumptive*, *summative*, or *free* modifier. You have probably never heard these terms before, but they name stylistic devices you have read many times and so should know how to use.

Resumptive Modifiers These two examples contrast a relative clause and a resumptive modifier:

Since mature writers often use resumptive modifiers to extend a line of thought, we need a word to name what I have not done in this sentence, **which I could have ended at that comma but extended to show you a relative clause attached to a noun.**

- ✓ Since mature writers often use resumptive modifiers to extend a line of thought, we need a word to name what I am about to do in this sentence, **a sentence that I could have ended at that comma but extended to show you how resumptive modifiers work.**

The boldfaced resumptive modifier repeats a key word, *sentence*, and rolls on.

To create a resumptive modifier, find the noun the tacked-on clause modifies, pause after it with a comma, repeat the noun, and continue with a restrictive relative clause beginning with *that*:

Since mature writers often use resumptive modifiers to extend a line of thought, we need a word to name what I am about to do in **this sentence,**

a sentence that I could have ended at that comma, but extended to show you how resumptive modifiers work.

You can also resume with an adjective or verb. In that case, you don't add a relative clause; you just repeat the adjective or verb and continue:

- ✓ It was American writers who found a voice that was both **true and lyrical,**
true to the rhythms of the working man's speech and **lyrical** in its celebration of his labor.
- ✓ All who value independence should **resist** the trivialization of government regulation,
resist its obsession with administrative tidiness and compulsion to arrange things not for our convenience but for theirs.

Occasionally, you can create a resumptive modifier with the phrase *one that*:

- ✓ I now address a problem we have wholly ignored, **one that** has plagued societies that sell their natural resources to benefit a few today rather than using them to develop new resources that benefit everyone tomorrow.

Summative Modifiers Here are two sentences that contrast relative clauses and summative modifiers. Notice how the *which* in the first one feels "tacked on":

Economic changes have reduced the region's population growth to less than zero, **which will have serious social implications.**

- ✓ Economic changes have reduced the region's population growth to less than zero, **a demographic event that will have serious social implications.**

To create a summative modifier, end a grammatically complete segment of a sentence with a comma, add a term that sums up the substance of the sentence so far, and continue with a restrictive relative clause beginning with *that*:

Economic changes have reduced the region's population growth to less than zero,

a demographic event that will have serious social implications.

A summative modifier has the same effect as a resumptive modifier: it lets you bring a clause to a sense of closure, then begin afresh.

Free Modifiers Like the other modifiers, a free modifier can appear at the end of a clause, but instead of repeating a key word or summing up what went before, it comments on the subject of the closest verb:

- ✓ Free modifiers resemble resumptive and summative modifiers, **letting you** [i.e., the free modifier lets you] **extend the line of a sentence while avoiding a train of ungainly phrases and clauses.**

Free modifiers usually begin with a present participle, as that one did, but they can also begin with a past participle, like this:

- ✓ Leonardo da Vinci was a man of powerful intellect, **driven by** [i.e., Leonardo was driven by] **an insatiable curiosity and haunted by a vision of artistic perfection.**

A free modifier can also begin with an adjective:

- ✓ In 1939, the U.S. began to assist the British against Germany, **aware** [i.e., the U.S. was aware] **that it faced another world war.**

We call these modifiers *free* because they can either begin or end a sentence:

- ✓ **Driven by an insatiable curiosity**, Leonardo da Vinci was...
- ✓ **Aware that it faced another world war**, the U.S. in 1939 began...

Here's the point: When you have to write a long sentence, don't just string together phrases and clauses, willy-nilly. Particularly avoid tacking one relative clause onto another onto another. Try extending the line of a sentence with resumptive, summative, and free modifiers.

4. Coordinate

COORDINATION is the foundation of a gracefully shaped sentence. It's harder to create good coordination than good modifiers, but when done well, it's more graceful. Compare these. My version is first; the original is second:

The aspiring artist may find that even a minor, unfinished work which was botched may be an instructive model for how things should be done, while for the amateur spectator, such works are the daily fare which may provide good, honest nourishment, which can lead to an appreciation of deeper pleasures that are also more refined.

- ✓ For the aspiring artist, the minor, the unfinished, or even the botched work, may be an instructive model for how things should—and should not be done. For the amateur spectator, such works are the daily fare which provide good, honest nourishment—and which can lead to appreciation of more refined, or deeper pleasures.

—Eva Hoffman, "Minor Art Offers Special Pleasures"

My revision sprawls through a string of tacked-on clauses.

The aspiring artist may find that even a minor, unfinished work **which** was botched may be an instructive model for **how** things should be done, **while** for the amateur spectator, such works are the daily fare

which may provide good, honest nourishment, **which** can lead to an appreciation of deeper pleasures **that** are also more refined.

Hoffman's original gets its shape from its multiple coordinations. Structurally, it looks like this:

For the aspiring artist, { the minor,
the unfinished,
or
even the botched } work may be
an instructive model for how things { should
and
should not } be done.

For the amateur spectator, such works are

the daily fare { which provide { good,
honest } nourishment—
and
which can lead to appreciation of { more refined,
or
deeper } pleasures. }

That second sentence in particular shows how elaborate coordination can get.

A UNIFYING PRINCIPLE: SHORT TO LONG

We should note a feature that distinguishes well-formed coordination. You can hear it if you read this next sentence aloud:

We should devote a few final words to a matter that reaches beyond the techniques of research to the connections between those subjective values that reflect our deepest ethical choices and objective research.

That sentence seems to end too abruptly with *objective research*. Structurally, it looks like this:

... between { those subjective values that reflect our
deepest ethical choices
and
objective research. }

This next revision moves from shorter to longer by reversing the two coordinate elements and by adding a PARALLELISM to the second one to make it longer still. Read this one aloud:

- ✓ We should devote a few final words to a matter that reaches beyond the techniques of research to the connections between objective research and those subjective values that reflect our deepest ethical choices and strongest intellectual commitments.

Structurally, it looks like this:

✓ ... between { objective research
and
those subjective
values that reflect our } { deepest ethical choices
and
strongest intellectual
commitments. }

A characteristic of especially elegant prose is how its writers elaborate all these devices for extending the line of a sentence, especially balanced coordination. I will discuss those devices and their elaboration in Lesson 11.

This principle of short to long is, in fact, one of the unifying principles of a clear prose style:

- It applies to the subject-verb sequence of individual sentences: the shorter the better to introduce the longer, more complex elements that follow.
- It applies to the principle of old before new: old information is usually objectively shorter than new information, but it is “psychologically” shorter, as well.
- It applies to ordering the logical elements of a long sentence: begin with its short point, then add the longer and more complex information that explains or supports it.
- It applies again here in balanced coordination: put shorter elements before longer ones.

Here's the point: Coordination lets you extend the line of a sentence more gracefully than by tacking on one element to another. When you can coordinate, try to order the elements so that they go from shorter to longer, from simpler to more complex.

QUICK TIP You can emphasize a coordination with CORRELATIVE CONJUNCTIONS: *both X and Y, not only X but also Y, (n)either X (n)or Y*. Compare these:

- ✓ The Golden Gate Bridge is an engineering marvel and a construction of stunning beauty.
- ✓ The Golden Gate Bridge is **both** an engineering marvel **and** a construction of stunning beauty.

When you use one of these conjunctions, however, be sure to put the *and*, *but*, or *(n)or* before a word that is coordinate with what follows the *both*, *not only*, and *(n)either*. In the first sentence below, *not only* precedes the verb while the *but* precedes its subject:

When you punctuate carefully, you **not only** *help* readers understand a complex sentence more easily, **but** you enhance your own image as a good writer.

They should precede the same part of speech:

- ✓ When you punctuate carefully, you **not only** *help* readers understand a complex sentence more easily, **but** *enhance* your own image as a good writer.

Exercise 10.2

Edit these sentences to address redundancy, wordiness, nominalizations, and other problems. Then create resumptive, summative, and free modifiers. In the first two, start a resumptive modifier with the word in boldface. Then use the word in brackets to create another sentence with a summative modifier. For example:

Within ten years, we could meet our energy **needs** with solar power.
[a possibility]

Resumptive:

- ✓ Within ten years, we could meet our energy **needs** with solar power, **needs** that will soar as our population grows.

Summative:

- ✓ Within ten years, we could meet our energy needs with solar power, **a possibility** that few anticipated ten years ago.

Free:

- ✓ Within ten years, we could meet our energy needs with solar power, **freeing** ourselves of dependence on foreign oil.

But before you begin adding modifiers, edit these sentences for redundancy, wordiness, nominalizations, and other problems.

1. Many different school systems are making a return back to traditional education in the **basics**. [a change]
2. Within the period of the last few years or so, automobile manufacturers have been trying to meet new and more stringent-type quality control **requirements**. [a challenge]
3. The reasons for the cause of aging are a puzzle that has perplexed humanity for millennia.
4. The majority of young people in the world of today cannot even begin to have an understanding of the insecurity that a large number of older people had experienced during the period of the Great Depression.

TROUBLESHOOTING LONG SENTENCES

Even when they begin well and don't sprawl, long sentences can still go wrong. Here are some common problems.

Faulty Grammatical Coordination

Ordinarily, we coordinate elements only of the same grammatical structure: clause and clause, prepositional phrase and prepositional phrase, and so on. When you coordinate different grammatical structures, readers may feel you have created an offensive lack of parallelism. Careful writers avoid this:

The committee recommends { **revising the curriculum** to recognize trends in local employment
and
that the division be reorganized to reflect the new curriculum. }

They would correct that to this:

✓... recommends { **that the curriculum be revised** to recognize ...
and
that the division be reorganized to reflect. ... }

Or to this:

✓... recommends { **revising the curriculum** to recognize ...
and
reorganizing the division to reflect. ... }

However, some nonparallel coordinations do occur in well-written prose. Careful writers coordinate a noun phrase with a *how* clause:

✓ We will attempt to delineate { **the problems** of education in developing nations
and
how coordinated efforts can address them in economical ways. }

They coordinate an adverb with a prepositional phrase:

✓ The proposal appears to have been written { **quickly, carefully,**
and
with the help of many. }

Careful readers do not blink at either.

Faulty Rhetorical Coordination

We respond to coordination best when the elements are coordinate not only in grammar but also in thought. Some

inexperienced writers coordinate by just joining one element to another with *and*:

Grade inflation is a problem at many universities, **and** it leads to a devaluation of good grades earned by hard work **and** will not be solved simply by grading harder.

Those *ands* obscure the relationships among those claims:

- ✓ Grade inflation is a problem at many universities, **because** it devalues good grades that were earned by hard work, **but** it will not be solved simply by grading harder.

Unfortunately, I can't tell you how to recognize when elements are not coordinate in thought, except to say, "Watch for it."

Unclear Connections

Readers are bothered by a coordination so long that they lose track of its internal connections and pronoun references:

Teachers should remember that students are vulnerable and uncertain about those everyday ego-bruising moments that adults ignore and that they do not understand that one day they will become as confident and as secure as the adults that bruise them.

We sense a flicker of hesitation about where to connect:

... and that they do not understand that one day they...

To revise a sentence like that, shorten the first half of the coordination so that you can start the second half closer to the point where the coordination began:

- ✓ Teachers should remember that students are vulnerable to ego-bruising moments that adults ignore and that they do not understand that one day...

Or repeat a word that reminds the reader where the coordination began (thereby creating a resumptive modifier):

- ✓ Teachers should remember that students are vulnerable to ego-bruising moments that adults ignore, **to remember** that they do not understand that...

Or repeat a noun to avoid an ambiguous pronoun:

- ✓ Teachers should remember that **students** are vulnerable to ego-bruising moments that adults ignore and that **students** do not understand that one day...

Ambiguous Modifiers

Sometimes modifiers are positioned so that readers are unsure what they modify:

Overtaxing oneself in physical activity too frequently results in injury.

What happens too frequently, overtaxing or injuries? We can make its meaning unambiguous by moving *too frequently*:

- ✓ Overtaxing oneself too frequently in physical activity results in injury.
- ✓ Overtaxing oneself in physical activity results too frequently in injury.

A modifier at the end of a clause can ambiguously modify either a neighboring or a more distant phrase:

Scientists have learned that their observations are as subjective as those in any other field **in recent years**.

We can move the modifier to a less ambiguous position:

- ✓ **In recent years**, scientists have learned that...
- ✓ Scientists have learned that **in recent years**...

Dangling Modifiers

Another problem with a long sentence can be a dangling modifier. A modifier dangles when its implied subject differs from the explicit subject of the main clause:

To overcome chronic poverty and lagging economic development in sub-Saharan Africa, ^{dangling modifier} a commitment to health and education ^{whole subject} is necessary for there to be progress in raising standards of living.

The implied subject of *overcome* is some unnamed agent, but the explicit subject of the main clause is *commitment*. To undangle the modifier, we make its implicit subject explicit:

- ✓ If **developed countries** are to overcome chronic poverty and lagging economic development in sub-Saharan Africa, a commitment to health and education is necessary...

Or better, make the implicit subject of the modifier the explicit subject of the clause:

- ✓ To overcome chronic poverty and lagging economic development in sub-Saharan Africa, **developed countries** must commit themselves to...

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Exercise 10.3

Two rules of thumb for beginning sentences are (1) get to the subject quickly and (2) get to the verb and object quickly (see pp. 140–143). Go through a page of your writing and underline the first seven or eight words of every sentence. Revise those in which you do not come to the subject and the verb in those opening words.

Exercise 10.4

It is difficult for writers to identify their bad habits, because they know their own writing too well. So have a reader help you identify yours:

- Do you take too long to get to your subjects and verbs?
- Are your subjects too long?
- Do you interrupt the connection between subject and verb, or verb and object?
- Do you take too long to make your point (in sentences and in passages)?
- Do you add subordinate clause to subordinate clause to subordinate clause?

Have a reader go through a few pages of your writing and draw a line beside any passages that seemed unclear or difficult to get through, naming the cause of the difficulty if she can. If she can't, analyze the rough passages together. (You can trust a reader's judgment that *something* is amiss, even if that reader can't say exactly *what*.) Then revise.

SUMMING UP

Here are the principles for giving sentences a coherent shape:

1. Get quickly to the subject, then to the verb and its object:
 - a. Avoid long introductory phrases and clauses. Revise them into their own INDEPENDENT CLAUSES:

Since most undergraduate students change their major fields of study at least once during their college careers, many more than once, **first-year students** who are not certain about the

program of studies they want to pursue should not load up their schedules to meet requirements for a particular program.

- ✓ **Most undergraduate students** change their major fields of study at least once during their college careers, so **first-year students** should not load up their schedules with requirements for a particular program if they are not certain about the program of studies they want to pursue.

- b. Avoid long subjects. Revise a long subject into an introductory subordinate clause:

A company that focuses on hiring the best personnel and then trains them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees.

- ✓ **When a company focuses on hiring the best personnel and then trains them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs later**, it is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees.

If the new introductory clause is long, shift it to the end of its sentence:

- ✓ A company is likely to earn the loyalty of its employees **when it focuses on hiring the best personnel...**

Or just break it out in a sentence of its own:

- ✓ **Some companies focus on hiring the best personnel and then train them not just for the work they are hired to do but for higher-level jobs later.** Such companies are likely to earn the loyalty of their employees.

- c. Avoid interrupting subjects and verbs and also verbs and objects. Move the interrupting element to either the beginning or end of the sentence, depending on what the next sentence is about:

Some scientists, **because they write in a style that is impersonal and abstract**, do not easily communicate with laypeople.

- ✓ **Since some scientists write in a style that is impersonal and abstract**, they do not easily communicate with laypeople. *This lack of communication damages....*

- ✓ Some scientists do not easily communicate with laypeople **because they write in a style that is impersonal and abstract.** *It is a kind of style filled with passives....*

2. Open the sentence with its point in a short main clause stating the key claim that you want the sentence to make:

A new sales initiative that has created a close integration between the garden and home products departments has made significant improvements to the customer services that Acme offers.

- ✓ Acme has significantly improved its customer services with a new sales initiative that closely integrates the garden and home products departments.

3. After the main clause, avoid adding one subordinate clause to another to another to another:

- a. Trim relative clauses and break the sentences into two:

Of the many areas of science **that** are important to our future, few are more promising than genetic engineering, **which** is a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, **which** are the genes and chromosomes **that** tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts **that** constitute our bodies.

- ✓ Many areas of science are important to our future, but few are more promising than genetic engineering. It is a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, **which** are the genes and chromosomes **that** tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts that constitute our bodies.
- ✓ Of the many areas of science ~~that are~~ important to our future, few are more promising than genetic engineering, ~~which is~~ a new way of manipulating the elemental structural units of life itself, ~~which are~~ the genes and chromosomes that tell our cells how to reproduce to become the parts **that** constituting our bodies.

- b. Extend a sentence with a resumptive, summative, or free modifier:

- ✓ **Resumptive:** When we discovered the earth was not the center of the universe, it changed our understanding of who we are, **an understanding changed again by Darwin, again by Freud, and again by Einstein.**

- ✓ **Summative:** American productivity has risen to new heights, **an achievement that only a decade ago was considered an impossible dream.**

- ✓ **Free:** Global warming will become a central political issue of the twenty-first century, **raising questions whose answers will affect the standard of living in every Western nation.**

- c. Coordinate elements that are parallel both in grammar and in sense:

Besides the fact that no civilization has experienced such rapid alterations in their spiritual and mental lives, the material conditions of their daily existence have changed greatly too.

- ✓ No civilization has experienced such rapid alterations in their spiritual and mental lives and in the material conditions of daily existence.

A last note: to write a long complex sentence that is also clear, you may need punctuation to help your reader through it. See Appendix I.